

Sirui (Sherry) Cai

Department of Real Estate, J. Mack Robinson College of Business
Georgia State University, Atlanta, GA

scai2@gsu.edu | siruisherrycai.github.io | [LinkedIn](#)

Education

- **Georgia State University** 2021–2027 (expected)
Ph.D., Business Administration (Concentration in Real Estate)
- **University of Warwick** 2019–2020
M.Sc., Business and Finance
- **Hong Kong Baptist University** 2015–2019
B.A., Accounting

Research Fields

Household Finance; Mortgages; Urban Economics; Commercial Real Estate; Generative AI

Job Market Paper

- **Do Lenders Underestimate Job Loss Risk?**

Sole authored, 2026

Does mortgage underwriting capture borrowers' job-loss risk? I construct an ex-ante job insecurity index from LinkedIn career histories at the occupation $\times$ metropolitan-area and industry $\times$ metropolitan-area level, combining how often workers are involuntarily separated with the wage loss they bear on reemployment, and validate both parts against BLS, JOLTS, and Displaced Worker Survey benchmarks. Linking the index to housing transactions, mortgage applications, and GSE loan performance over 2005–2023, I find that both occupation and industry insecurity predict serious delinquency beyond FICO, DTI, LTV, and local conditions, raising the two-year default probability by about 0.25 percentage points per standard deviation — a roughly 12 percent increase relative to the 2.2 percent average two-year default rate in the sample — and the index survives a horse race against the conventional two-year employment screen and realized unemployment benchmarks. Lenders respond only in part: approval rates fall modestly with industry risk, the interest rate does not compensate it, and loans in higher-industry-risk areas are more likely to be securitized. Job-loss risk is thus underpriced at origination, and the unpriced exposure is transferred to the GSEs.

Publications

- **Evaluating Inconsistencies in Assessment Regressivity Across Property Classes**

with Jon Wiley

Real Estate Economics, 2026

We investigate inconsistencies in property tax assessment regressivity across property classes using public record data from Cook County, Illinois during 2006–2022. Across a battery of tests, we document that assessment regressivity is severe within Class 3 (large residential), Class 5A (commercial), and Class 5B (industrial), whereas assessment ratios are only marginally regressive within Class 2 (small residential). Property Classes 3, 5A, and 5B are significantly more likely to appeal, have successful appeals, and have greater value reductions following a successful appeal, compared to Class 2. The appeal process acts to further exacerbate regressivity within Classes 5A and 5B. We calculate the counterfactual tax rate that could have been applied under the hypothetical scenario of zero regressivity within each property class and assuming that assessment ratios equal official assessment rates. The weighted average tax rate across jurisdictions in Cook County during 2006–2022 is 7.8% and the counterfactual tax rate we calculate that produces the same property tax revenue under the above conditions would have been 6.1%.

Working Papers

- **Political Alignment and Neighborhood Choice Among Homebuyers**

with Yongqiang Chu, Thao Le, and Lily Shen

2026

We study the impact of buyers' political identity on home purchasing using North Carolina voter records linked to more than 250,000 housing transactions and over six million comparable MLS listings. Using a Bartik-type shift-share IV framework, we find that buyers are significantly more likely to purchase homes in politically aligned neighborhoods, with alignment increasing purchase probability by about 1.58 percentage points relative to a 3 percent baseline. The effect is strongest among Republican buyers and declines sharply from 2010 to 2019 despite rising national polarization.

Presented at: AREUEA–ASSA Conference (2027)*; ARES 42nd Annual Meeting, Destin, FL (2026); Homer Hoyt Institute, West Palm Beach, FL (2026)*

- **Flood Insurance Repricing as a Mortgage Credit Shock: Evidence from FEMA's Risk Rating 2.0**

with Lily Shen

2026

We study whether actuarial flood insurance repricing is transmitted to real estate markets through mortgage credit. FEMA's Risk Rating 2.0 (RR 2.0) replaced the National Flood Insurance Program's zone-based pricing system with property-level actuarial rates. Using NFIP policy microdata, ZTRAX housing transactions, and HMDA mortgage applications for Florida, we identify tracts exposed to premium increases and examine both housing-price capitalization and mortgage-credit responses. Treated tracts experience an average 2% sale-price decline and a 1.4 percentage-point drop in mortgage approval rates. Application volume does not fall detectably, but approval declines are concentrated among low-income applicants, while high-income applicants experience little detectable change. Price effects do not vary systematically with tract-level educational attainment, providing limited support for a pure household-learning explanation. Banks and nonbanks reduce approvals at similar rates, but nonbanks additionally raise interest rates and securitize more originated loans in treated tracts. The results identify a lender-mediated affordability channel: flood insurance repricing raises current and expected total housing costs, and mortgage lenders transmit this shock by tightening credit for borrowers with limited income capacity.

Presented at: AREUEA–ASSA Conference (2027); Cambridge Real Estate Finance and Investment Symposium (2026)*; JRER/UCF Current Issues in Real Estate Symposium, Orlando, FL (2026)*; ARES 42nd Annual Meeting, Destin, FL (2026)

Previously circulated as "Who Prices Flood Risk and When: Evidence from Housing Markets."

- **The Distributional Burden of Actuarial Flood Insurance Reform: Evidence from FEMA's Risk Rating 2.0**

with Lily Shen

2026 (under revision)

Risk Rating 2.0 (RR 2.0) replaced the National Flood Insurance Program's zone-based premiums with property-level actuarial rates. Linking NFIP policy microdata with ACS demographics and ZTRAX transactions for Florida, we study how this repricing affects both recurring ownership costs and residential transaction prices. Upward repricing is more common in higher-income tracts and slightly larger in dollar terms, yet the premium burden is sharply regressive: bottom-quintile tracts face premium-to-income ratios 2.5× those of top-quintile tracts ([X.X]% vs. [Y.Y]%), a gap driven by income scaling rather than larger dollar increases. A two-phase difference-in-differences design comparing positive-repricing tracts with flat or downward-repricing tracts shows that sale prices fall by about 2%, reaching 2.6% after the renewal phase, with capitalization concentrated in low-income tracts and near zero in high-income tracts. In a 30-year accounting exercise, combining the premium stream with the estimated mark-to-market price discount implies combined homeowner exposure of [A.A]% of annual household income for bottom-quintile policyholders versus [B.B]% for top-quintile policyholders. Although upward repricing is concentrated in higher-income tracts, the income-scaled burden and price discounts fall most heavily on lower-income markets.

Conference Presentations

- AREUEA–ASSA Conference, Washington, DC (Jan. 2027)

- Financial Management Association Annual Meeting, Tampa, FL (Oct. 2026)
- Cambridge Real Estate Finance and Investment Symposium, Cambridge, UK (Sep. 2026)*
- JRER/UCF Current Issues in Real Estate Symposium, Orlando, FL (Mar. 2026)*
- American Real Estate Society, 42nd Annual Meeting, Destin, FL (Mar. 2026)
- Homer Hoyt Institute, West Palm Beach, FL (Jan. 2026)*

* indicates presentation by a co-author.

Teaching Experience

Instructor, Georgia State University

- | | |
|--|----------------|
| • Real Estate Market Analysis, Spring 2026 | Rating: 4.90/5 |
| • Real Estate Investments, Fall 2025 & Fall 2026 | Rating: 4.60/5 |
| • Real Estate Finance, Spring 2025 | Rating: 4.85/5 |
| • Real Estate Asset Management, Fall 2024 | Rating: 4.80/5 |

Teaching Assistant

- Real Estate Principles, Georgia State University, 2022–2024
- Corporate Finance, BNU–HKBU United International College, 2020

Awards and Fellowships

- GSU Graduate Teaching Assistant Teaching Excellence Award (2026)
- ARES Doctoral Travel Grant (2026)
- RERI Student Stipend Award (2024)
- Wolverton Doctoral Award (2024)
- HKBU Scholastic Awards (2019)
- HKICPA Qualification Program Scholarship (2018)
- First-Class Scholarship (2016, 2017, 2018)

Professional Service

- Referee, *Journal of Commodity Markets* (2025)
- Organizer, GSU Finance Ph.D. Meeting Series (2024–2025)

Skills and Data Experience

Software: Stata, SAS, Python, ArcGIS, L^AT_EX

Data: Revelio Labs LinkedIn Data; CoreLogic Housing Transaction Data; ATTOM Housing Transaction Data; Zillow ZTRAX Data; HMDA Data; MLS Data; Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac GSE Performance Data; CoStar Data; Cook County (IL) Public Records on Property Tax Assessment

Additional Information

Languages: Chinese (native), English (professional)

Volunteer: Georgia Aquarium

Last updated: August 17, 2026